

"The way forward is to win hearts. Not a single Kashmiri Muslim will tell you that they don't want the Hindus back"

India—in three or four seats, but they could have been challenged.

Q. What did your party do for the Kashmiri Pandits when it ruled from 2008 to 2014?
A. Thanks to Manmohan Singhji, who was the PM then, our governments were able to give Kashmiri Pandits more than 3,000 jobs that were created for them. We thought of bringing back their families to the Valley by building transit accommodations so that the process of returning could begin. The second thing we did was to increase their stipends, their rations, and make them comfortable in every way, wherever they were. Has the Modi government done any of this so far in the almost eight years they have been in power? I will be the first person to admit that we didn't do everything. The problem is far larger than that. But we didn't make the situation worse.

Q. The Modi government can argue that they made the Valley more secure for the Pandits to return by abrogating Article 370...
A. The recent killing of the chemist (Makhan Lal) Bindroo led every Hindu employee who had come to run back to Jammu overnight. Is this what the abrogation of Article 370 has achieved? Why weren't they able to stop them from fleeing with all the force that they have here? If the situation was normal, would they have fled? And imagine, in the budget that they presented, the budget for our state, they allocated 80 per cent to security and 20 per cent to development. How much development can you expect with 20 per cent and for people who stand with the nation?

Q. What do you think has been the impact of abrogating Article 370?
A. They said Article 370 was behind all the tragedies and that militancy would be wiped out once it was gone. I want to ask the Government of India and the home minister, who made the announcement: Has the militancy gone? Are people not dying anymore? Are there no bombs going off anywhere? These things are still happening and the militants are coming not only from Pakistan. They are also from here, from our people. What is making them do all this? Why are they feeling alienated enough to give up their lives? The time has come when we must try and find the cause and treat it, rather than allow it to drift till it becomes so dangerous that nobody knows what the end will be.

Q. Have things changed in the Valley since the prime minister met Kashmiri leaders, including you?
A. I had told the prime minister frankly then that we don't trust you and you don't trust us, let us try and create that trust which will build the future of our nation. He promised us in his speech that he will try to eliminate this '*dil ki doori aur Delhi ki doori*'. But nothing has happened in that direction. It is not development, it is not whether you send us gold or silver, it is how you heal hearts; hearts cannot be healed by making roads and bridges. There is something more than that: trust. We must build trust in each other so that we can survive together, live together, progress together and be happy together rather than create animosity among people.

Q. Does this include holding assembly elections and restoring statehood?
A. Yes. I think this is the first example, maybe in the world, where a state that is supposed to be the crown of a country is cut into two. Not only this, look at the way the Delimitation Commission has divided our seats. They want to impose BJP rule.

Q. Are you saying the BJP wants a Hindu chief minister to rule J&K?
A. They can do anything, let them try this experiment too. They are pushing J&K in such hands that god help you.

Q. Would you accept a Hindu CM?
A. If there is honest delimitation and elections, it won't matter to me who becomes the chief minister because the people would have chosen him. He won't be thrust on them. Recently, a Union minister came to Kathua to inaugurate Maharaja Gulab Singh's statue. I wanted to ask the minister where that state of Maharaja Gulab Singh is. If it doesn't exist, then why put his statue at the entry point of this state? Please explain it to the people of this state and the rest of the country.

Q. Finally, what kind of closure do you think Kashmiri Pandits need?
A. The way forward is to win people's hearts. Not a single Kashmiri Muslim will tell you that they don't want the Hindus to come back. But will this film promote their coming back? That is my question to them. ■